DOUBLE ISSUE

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Person *of the* Year

TIME

DONALD TRUMP

PRESIDENT OF THE DIVIDED STATES OF AMERICA

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The Choice

Gibbs, a former writer and editor in chief at TIME, is the director of the Shorenstein Center and the visiting Edward R. Murrow professor at Harvard Kennedy School. She is the co-author, along with Michael Duffy, of two best-selling presidential histories: *The President's Club: Inside the World's Most Exclusive Fraternity* and *The Preacher and the Presidents: Billy Graham in the White House*.

This is the 90th time we have named the person who had the greatest influence, for better or worse, on the events of the year. So which is it this year: Better or worse? The challenge for Donald Trump is how profoundly the country disagrees about the answer….Read the full story here.

Read more:
TIME's 2016 Person of the Year: Donald Trump

Runner-Up: Hillary Clinton

Runner-Up: The Hackers

Runner-Up: Recep Tayyip Erdogan

Runner-Up: The CRISPR Pioneers

Runner-Up: Beyoncé

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The Teddy Awards, Even In a Year That Set New Lows for Politicians

It isn't easy to bestow awards for political courage in an election year–and it's near impossible after a campaign like the one we've just experienced, which set a sad new standard for ugliness and mendacity. But as an eternal optimist, I proceed with my annual chore and will even say something nice about Donald Trump, who ran the most disgraceful presidential campaign that I can remember–but, in the course of which, took several positions athwart the traditions of the Republican Party. He supported gay rights and admitted that the war in Iraq was a mistake. Granted, these were positions that had long been obvious to a majority of Americans, but not to the GOP. He defied evangelicals on the gay-rights issue (and also in his support for Planned Parenthood) and still won their votes.

I wish I could say that Hillary Clinton had similar moments of courage, moments when she defied her party's entrenched base, but she didn't. She must receive credit, however, for her seriousness, for the honorable detail of her policy papers–roundly ignored in a year when the size of hands loomed larger than the size of budgets. There are still important things she can do for our country. I hope she finds a new role in the arena, after a suitable time to rest, reflect and wipe off the blood and dust.

I'll have more to say about Barack Obama elsewhere in these pages, but there are two important achievements of the President's time in office that need to be acknowledged. One is the stimulus plan he fought for and passed in 2009, which prevented a depression and responsibly laid the groundwork for the economic recovery we're now experiencing. (Those Democrats who believe that the 2016 election was lost only because of economics are

deluding themselves; it was lost because of tribalism.) And overseas, Obama made some mistakes, but he got the big things right: he was not arrogant, he was not bellicose, he reached out to enemies in Cuba and Iran–gestures that will eventually pay off, I believe–and most important, he was confident that our ways will prevail over Islamic extremism (just ask any man or woman in Mosul how they felt about ISIS rule).

Some other political Teddys: to Jeb Bush for running the Republican equivalent of the Clinton campaign, stuffed with great policy ideas … to John Kasich, for running with his heart on his sleeve … to Bernie Sanders, for giving young people something to care about and, postelection, for speaking out against identity politics. And in a major break with tradition, I'd like to bestow a prospective pair of Teddys to Senators Chuck Schumer and Lamar Alexander, who will have the difficult task of reforming–the Republicans will call it "replacing"–Obamacare. Both are good men, members of the Senate's sanity caucus, and I predict they'll find a way to get this difficult job done.

And Teddys go to another unlikely pair: William Kristol and William Galston, who have disagreed about many things over the years but now agree that there is a need for a new center movement, mindful of tradition, stability and accountability, free from the excesses of left and right. Along those same lines, courageous work was done this year by the conservative writers who boldly opposed Trump, for all the right reasons, and will now pay the consequences of being shut off from a Republican Administration: Pete Wehner and David Brooks of the New York Times, Bret Stephens of the Wall Street Journal and Mike Gerson of the Washington Post, among others.

I've covered 11 presidential campaigns, which is more than enough. This one was my last. I'd like to thank my editors–Nancy Gibbs, Michael Duffy and Michael Scherer–for giving me the freedom to speak my mind, and you, dear readers, for your

tolerance of my oft-cranky centrism. It has been a privilege to serve you.

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In 2016, Lies, the Whole Lies and Nothing but the Lies

Lying used to be dangerous. Your nose might grow, your trousers could combust or a wolf might eat you. But this year, lying proved profitable, even for those who got caught. After a deluge of fake news stories, concocted debate facts and ads at the bottom of Internet articles for stories about how I will not believe what 1990s celebrities look like now when they actually look just like I thought they would–a lot of people are saying that 2016 was the Year of the Lie. If lying had been this acceptable in 1789, George Washington would have had the President's residence constructed entirely of free cherrywood.

Oxford dictionaries chose post-truth as the word of the year. Is that true? Is there even an "Oxford Dictionaries"? Facts like that don't matter in a year when people cared so little about lying. Mendacity created so little furor that for the first time in 34 years, no one bothered to start a rumor that Abe Vigoda had died, possibly making Abe Vigoda feel so ignored, it caused him to die. The Chicago Cubs were embraced despite being caught lying for 71 years about being cursed by a goat, when their real problem was

that no one in the organization had ever thought to hire all the executives and players from the Red Sox.

Pro-Brexit ads on the sides of buses–many of which were twice as high as normal bus ads–claimed that Britain paid £350 million every week to the E.U. and would redirect that cash to the National Health Service; most people knew neither was true, but it didn't stop Brexit from winning. Hillary Clinton spun such an enormous, complicated web of cover-ups about her email server that not one person understood what she had done, including Hillary Clinton. North Carolina got away with passing a law by lying about men lying about being transgender to peep at women in bathroom stalls–which wouldn't even make sense if free porn didn't exist.

Senate Republicans kept their majority even though they wouldn't vote on confirming Supreme Court appointee Merrick Garland because, Mitch McConnell said, it is necessary to "let the American people decide" this, even though the Constitution specifically says the American people should definitely not decide this. Brock Turner lied about sexually assaulting an unconscious woman at Stanford and got convicted, but served only three months in jail. Olympic swimmer Ryan Lochte claimed men with badges robbed him at gunpoint in Rio, though it turned out it he just got yelled at by a gas-station attendant for vandalizing the bathroom. Yet weeks later he was on Dancing With the Stars, an honor second only to being President, according to the actions of Rick Perry, who signed up for the show after quitting the race.

The Year of the lie was great for the National Enquirer, which Donald Trump has written for since it is run by his friend. The paper reported that Clinton suffered from multiple sclerosis, depression and alcoholism. Infowars editor Alex Jones–whose radio show Trump loves and appeared on–believes that the moon landing was faked, 9/11 was faked and the Sandy Hook massacre was faked. And also that it's O.K. to run your Cyber Monday sale of Infowars' Super Male Vitality Formula way past Wednesday.

Trump mastered the lie. He saw Muslims in New Jersey celebrate the falling of the Twin Towers. He claimed that Clinton started the birther movement instead of him. He vowed to save $300 billion a year from Medicare's prescription-drug program, which costs $78 billion a year. After he won the presidency, he lied that millions of people had voted for Clinton illegally. It was the kind of year when you could even lie about being cheated after you won.

The only thing you were punished for this year was telling the truth. Larry Wilmore's Comedy Central show was canceled. James Comey decided to be totally up-front about every single thing he was thinking about and got persecuted for it. And a bunch of fact-checking organizations covered the election, only to be made fun of for being nerdy elites who care about facts.

It was a better year to be a columnist than a reporter. I look forward to at least four more.

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Amazing Grace

Eight years ago, toward the end of the 2008 presidential campaign, Michelle Obama asked me, “Klein, are you going to write a book like *Primary Colors* about us?” referring to my satirical novel about the 1992 campaign. I spluttered a bit; the thought had never occurred to me. Her husband started to laugh. “Klein can’t write a book like that about us,” he said. “We’re too boring.”

That was nonsense, of course. The first African-American President of the United States was never going to be boring. But Obama was right too. There would be little melodrama and absolutely no hint of scandal during his time in office. The conservative fever swamps would be no less pustulent than they were during the Clinton presidency–indeed, the level of race-based hatemongering was frightening–but somehow the Obamas never let it get to them. They radiated a sense of militant normality, a mother-knows-best family on the world’s brightest stage. The First Lady let the White House staff know that Sasha and Malia would make their own beds. The President went up to the residence for family dinner most nights. The First Lady planted a vegetable garden. She gave her husband grief when he got too full of himself.

When the President received the Nobel Peace Prize, he was asked to sign his name and leave a brief message in the same book that previous recipients, like Albert Schweitzer and Martin Luther King Jr., had signed. Obama sat before the book and, in his precise, architectural left-handed script, began to write and write … and write. Finally, Michelle intervened: “Honey, are you writing a book?”

Their physical, emotional and intellectual grace was daunting. They never lost their cool in public. He controlled a supersharp sense of irony; he was never harsh. He made plenty of mistakes, as all

Presidents do. He declared a “red line” in Syria and did nothing when it was crossed. He did not pretend to like the social ceremonies of politics; he despised flattery. I once asked a top aide why the President didn’t invite his opponents over to the White House for a drink or a movie more often and was told, “He believes they’d see right through it.” True enough, but there isn’t a soul in Washington who isn’t thrilled by an invitation to the White House.

The impact of the Obamas on American culture was subtle but substantial. In the Klein household these days, Dad is reading a book (Sapiens, by the Israeli historian Yuval Noah Harari) that the President included in his list of 10 essential books, while the kids are watching the First Lady’s epic Carpool Karaoke and the whole family dances together to the President’s daytime playlist. The Obamas demonstrated that you can get down without losing your dignity. Their tastes were an eclectic combination of high and low: her sophisticated and never-errant fashion sense; his unabashed love of ESPN and late-adopted passion for golf.

He will be remembered for his eulogies, the terrible skein of laments over the bodies of American citizens murdered. He could convey a cathartic sadness, and the potential for uplift, in the face of tragedy. His most perfect moment came at the funeral of the Charleston, S.C., churchgoers who had been killed by a sick white man. The families of the dead had already forgiven the shooter–a stupendous act, but not uncommon in the black church and the African-American experience. How to respond to that? Words couldn’t cover it … so he sang “Amazing Grace,” a moment of bravado, humility and passion entwined.

Boring? Not for a moment. Thank you, Mr. President and First Lady, for leading us so elegantly.

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The Best of Culture 2016

In a tumultuous year, the arts turned to explorations of identity, justice and intimacy. From a fierce Beyoncé anthem to the tale of an alienated man-horse, these works inspired both empathy and insight.

The 10 Best Albums
The 10 Best Shows
The 10 Best Movies
The 10 Best Performances
The 10 Best Songs
The 10 Best Novels
The 10 Best Nonfiction Books
The 10 Best Episodes

Plus more

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